THE SIMPLICITY OF CHRIST

VOLUME ONE

"ONLY FOR EARNEST SEEKERS OF THE TRUTH"

APOSTLE

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THE SIMPLICITY OF CHRIST

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Dedication

I dedicate this book in the hands of God Almighty. I pray that it may liberate the one who reads it and glorify God, whom I serve with my entire being.

Acknowledgements

I acknowledge and appreciate the work of the Holy Spirit without Him my writings are of no value. I also acknowledge the support from my lovely wife who always intercedes for me and encourages me in the Lord in the work of the ministry.

Preface

It is my strong belief that the following teachings contained in this book will help the reader have a solid foundation, built on true Biblical doctrines and the Lord Jesus Christ. I began writing this book in 2005 but could not publish it until now. It was not an easy task to put this book together. The sacrifice included sleepless nights, long working long hours, prayers, Bible study and spiritual experiences, and lonely times spent away from people and innocent enjoyments in order to give undivided attention to the writing of this book. If it took me so much time, energy, concentration and dependence on God's Spirit to produce such work, I believe you also need to treat this material with as much care in order to benefit from it.

I would like to pray for you and with you as you embark on this journey to read this book. "Thank you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth. You have concealed your ways from sophisticates and know-it-alls, but spelled them out clearly to ordinary people. I pray that the Lord will reveal Himself to you in a way that you understand even through these pages in Jesus name." Amen !

I have prayed for you my readers that this book will not become a manual of principles, but it will be a guide to experience as well. My desire is that you may experience the realities of the truths set forth in these writings. I had always hoped another more capable than I would undertake this work, yet it pleased the Lord to call me to do it. I have attempted to abdicate and eschew from God's responsibility especially that of shepherding his flock

but God arrested me by his grace. I hope He will enable me to put across what He has given me for the Church in written form and in an orderly and plain fashion that can be understood even by the least of the saints. You might wonder why you did not see such a book on the shelves. It was not yet time; God has His appointed times for everything on earth. I want my readers to know that it took me more than seven years and some months to release the first publication of this book. It took considerable time of studying the Bible, spiritual experiences with God and studying what God has done and is still doing in other people's lives.

It was very necessary for me to study various books from various men God has used in the past and that enriched my understanding. Books are very important, they help you learn some things that have taken others many years to learn in a shorter space of time and help you avoid errors others have taken years to learn to avoid. Much motivation to embark on such a work came about from the desire to know the truth and from a thorough observation of the modern day ministration of the gospel. I came to a point where I was hungry for something more than the junk in the spiritual space and religious arena being served as gospel to many hungry souls.

I felt there was a dearth of true religion and a missing piece somewhere and began my meticulous search for the truth. I found out that when it comes to the gospel of Christ, not even half of the truth had been told the Church. I am not at all implying that I found all the truth or received some higher revelation from God, but rather God gave me something for the

Church today. It is something that always was true for the Church; only that it took me long to notice it from the Scriptures. I hope it will save you many years of desperate search for answers and prevent you from making the numerous errors some preachers of the gospel often make in communicating the gospel to others.

There are those who take Christianity as a religion merely to appease the conscience while others take the gospel as a spiritual drug that lulls them away from reality and the miseries of life every time they meet with other believers. Some have given up their search for the truth because of the diverse heresies and dogmata that exists on earth. One man once said, "There is no one who knows the truth." I asked the man, "Do you have one hundred percent (100%) knowledge about everything?" He said, "No." I doubted if he had even an iota of truth in him. Then I said, "Do not conclude that no one really knows the truth because that is not true, the truth is that there could be someone who knows the other percentage of knowledge you do not have." All of us at some point in life will face the question regarding to our relationship with the truth. Pilate faced the truth but failed to recognize it. "Pilate saith unto him, What is truth? And when he had said this, he went out again unto the Jews, and saith unto them, I find no crime in him." (John 18:38, KJV) Pilate found nothing wrong in Christ but still failed to recognize truth even when he was face to face with the truth. Can you recognize truth when you see it? Pilate missed the truth because he was looking for a crime. Many people who came to Jesus to scrutinize Him with a wrong attitude often missed Him. Pilate looked for

evidence that made Jesus not fit to be the Messiah and fond none, yet he did not look for the evidence that made Him the Messiah.

Many people have not benefitted by their inquisitiveness about Christ because they get more curious as they move closer to the truth. Jesus had at some point said to Thomas, “I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.” (John 14:6, ESV) To the Jews that had believed in Him, He said, “If ye abide in my word, then are ye truly my disciples; and ye shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.” (John 8:31-32, KJV) God has given His manifold wisdom to the Church, but surprisingly not all members of the Church know this. This sought after truth really can be found and once found can liberate man as he beholds his God-intended purpose of existence. Ignorance and distortion of Bible teachings has diluted the gospel message and altered its requirements yet the true gospel remains impervious.



Apostle Tongai Godfrey Mapiye

Understanding the Bible

"How sweet are thy words unto my taste! Yea, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" (Psalm 119:103, KJV)

I felt it necessary to begin with the way a Christian needs to read their Bible as the starting point. If we fail to agree with the Spirit of Christ on how we interpret the Bible, we also fail in our Christian walk. I say this because one thing that I discovered after two years of being a Christian was that one must never rely on preachers of the Bible concerning what God actually said in the Bible. Many people have relegated the responsibility of their beliefs in the Bible to their preacher or their church denomination and this is very disastrous. It dawned on me that what God was revealing to me every time I read my Bible was very different from denominational teachings, sometimes the opposite of what was being preached in the denomination. I realized that denominational truth is not always the truth of the Bible. I decided early that I did not have to understand the Bible the way my Church denomination wanted me to understand it but I had the responsibility concerning my own beliefs. I did not let any man decide for me what the Bible was to me. I hope you will not let any human being decide for you what the Bible is but you will allow God to cause you to experience the reality of the Bible.

What is the Bible?

The word “Bible” comes from a Greek word meaning “books”. The Bible is can be regarded as two collections of books, often referred to as the “Old Testament” and the “New Testament.” The word translated “testament” historically was used to mean a covenant or agreement. It refers to God’s promise to bless his people. The Old Testament is generally that collection of writings that relate to the agreement that God made with the Jewish people (Israel) in time of Moses. The Old Testament does not begin in the book of Genesis as many people think, but somewhere in Exodus when God made His Covenant with Moses and the Israelites. The New Testament is the collection of writings that relate to the agreement that God made with all people who believe in Jesus Christ (both Jews and Gentiles). The New Testament began when Jesus ate the last supper with His disciples and became effective after His resurrection.

The Old Testament is divided into three main sections: the Law (Five Books of Moses also known as the Pentateuch), the Prophets, and the Holy Writings (Psalms, Poetry, Prose, Wise sayings, and Songs). The Ten Commandments and the rest of the teachings given at Mount Sinai became known as “the Law of Moses” or simply the Law. The Old Testament writings give an account of the great things God did for the Jewish people, and they tell of God’s plan for using those people to bring his blessings to the whole world. These writings point to the coming of a Saviour (or “Messiah”) that God would send to complete his plan. The New Testament writings continue the Old Testament story and carry it to the

consummation of God's eternal plan. They describe the coming of the Saviour (Jesus Christ) and the meaning of his coming for all people.

The Old Testament is important for understanding the New Testament, since it provides the necessary background for the salvation of mankind. The whole Bible contains a very important message, which is the salvation of mankind through God's gracious gift. The foundation of this mystery is set forth in the Old Testament and the New Testament completes the story of the salvation of mankind that began in the Old Testament.

When a Christian continues to study the Bible he will come to understand that New Testament was first preached to Abram who latter became Abraham (Gal 3, Gal 4, Rom 4 and Gen 12, 17, 18, 22). When God entered into Covenant with Abraham and promised to bless all nations through the Seed of Abraham. The Seed of Abraham is later revealed in the New Testament as Christ. The gospel of the New Testament was preached to Abraham through God's promise. Christ came as a child of promise to fulfill the Word of God.

At first when I began to study the Bible I failed to reconcile the Old Testament and the New Testament because I could not see that the Bible is all about Christ and man's salvation. As a Christian continues to study the Bible, he will come to the same conclusion that the Bible is about Christ. Reading the Bible is not just a matter of flipping pages and memorizing passages or verses but the Bible point us to the Person of Christ. When Christ is revealed to us in Scripture, we come to realize that

we can experience Him. When we experience Him we come to realize that the Bible reveals Christ and Christ reveals the Church and the Church reveals us in Christ. When this light is visible to us we begin to experience the Bible as intended by our Creator. The Bible ceases to be a lifeless book but becomes our spiritual food for our daily living.

Who wrote the Bible?

"Who wrote the Bible?" is a question that is undoubtedly asked by many who are familiar with the impact this book has made on people around the world. People want to know who wrote the Bible because of the authority it has on people and the way of life it teaches. The Bible demands for our obedience and places accountability on every person towards a Holy God and makes every man responsible for all his thoughts, actions and motives. The Bible governs all of man's affairs and relationships. It also touches even the most sensitive areas of our lives. This makes people question, who the author of the Bible is? If they can find grounds of dismissing the integrity of the Author then they can be sure to dismiss the contents.

Many people are in doubt and they always ask themselves, "Is the Bible really God's word?" Some try to ignore the answer to this question and try to hide behind their sinful lives and the deception of passing pleasures. The fact of the matter is for how long will they continue to hide just like

Adam and Eve behind the tree covered with fig leaves and is their covering enough to hide them from the presence of the Bible?

The truth we must all face is 2 Timothy 3:16 which states that "All scripture is inspired by God…." The Bible itself tells us that God is the Author of His book. If a man uses a pen to write a letter, who wrote the letter? Is it the man or the pen? Obviously, it is the man who wrote the letter using the medium of a pen. God wrote the Bible, through people that he prepared and inspired for this work. In 2 Peter 1:20-21, Peter reminds the reader to "know this first of all, that no prophecy of scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation … but men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God."

I remember before I got saved, how ignorant I was as regards to the Bible and how confused I was about the authority of the Book over humanity. I wondered whose Book it was and why it was written, because I had never understood its contents. I had never given enough time to the Bible so as to understand it. It was so contrary to my opinions about life. I thought the Bible was a white man's book, which was written to control people and reduce criminal behavior by giving people something to fear. Alas, how lost I was!

My first genuine encounter with the Bible

The problem we all have is that none of us was born holding a Bible in their hand. I grew up in a family with mixed beliefs. They believed in going

to Church, patronizing witchdoctors, ancestral worship and consulting false prophets. No matter how futile all these things were, they formed the basis of our belief system as a family. Most of the male folk in my family were drunkards and I also grew up to become a loyal descendant to this pattern of alcoholism. I remember coming home drunk, empty and unfulfilled and kneeling on my bed with tears in my eyes praying to God, "God, if you really exist, I want to know the truth. I don't know why you have made the truth so difficult to find. I don't know whether the Bible is really from you or just a white man's book. I am not worshipping because I do not know the truth. I don't want to worship something false. If you hide the truth from me, how do you expect me to worship? If you show me the truth I will worship you, but if you do not show me the truth I will not worship you. Right now I am drunk, but if you really exist, I know you can hear me and you know my thoughts." I sobbed that prayer and that was the time I really prayed, little did I know that God was drawing me to Himself.

After a few days, God showed me a vision that was an answer to my questions. Although I was a stranger to spiritual things and did not believe in the reality of heaven and heavenly beings, I was taken up into heaven. I saw angels. I saw one like the Son of Man. I could not look at His face due to the radiance. He said not a word. The angels were singing, but I could not understand their language. Their voices sounded like musical instruments. Then Jesus pulled out a Bible and handed it to one of the angels. The angels passed on the Bible one to another until it reached me.

I wondered why I was being given a Bible yet I was a drunkard. I opened it. The vision ended. When I woke up I did not understand what it meant.

The wonder of my first Bible

Although I did not understand this vision at that moment, I had two more visions that subsequently led to my conversion and one day as I was worshipping God during my devotions, God explained the visions after I had been born again. After my conversion, I did not have money to buy a Bible of my own, but I believed that if God gave me a Bible in a vision, He could physically give me one. I prayed for a Bible and God miraculously answered my prayer. My mother walked into some shop and bought me a Bible, exactly the same Bible I saw in the vision. I cherished that Bible and loved it so much. Though my mother was not saved, I knew God had used her. The Bible became my best friend as I had lost all my friends because of my faith in God. I read the Bible until my family members pitied me and thought I was mad or the Bible was making me lose my mind, but the Bible was bringing me into my right state of mind. The Bible is the book of our lives here on earth. When I read it I read as if my life depends on it. I know the Bible is God's book. I do not just believe what I want to believe like what many people choose to do. To me the Bible came from God. It is God's written revelation for us. My life finds its basis, purpose and destiny in the Bible. The Bible is the inspired word of God, and every child of God should spend time to study it. How I got my first Bible was not a coincidence, God showed me that the Bible came out of Him. I cannot

argue with atheists on this. I know Him whom I have believed on that He is true. If He chooses not to prove Himself to men, I can't either.

"Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, And light unto my path." (Psalm 119:105)

Why the Bible cannot be ignored?

The Bible cannot be ignored, it demands to be taken more serious than anything we will ever read or study in our lives on earth. The Bible is not another book to be read or one of many books, but it is the primary and the ultimate book that every human being must read. This is so because of its authority, the one who inspired it, its contents and its relevance to our daily lives. The Bible is a living book that reads you as much as you read it.

The Bible is a collection of books and not just verses and chapters. Books are meant to be read. When we do not read our Bibles we send a negative message to the one who inspired the writing of the Bible. Our opinions to the Bible will affect our relationship with the Bible. My opinion to the Bible is secondary to the Bible's opinion of me. What matters is not how I judge the Bible but how its Author judges me. The way we view God will affect the way we approach the Bible. Our view of God determines our view of the Bible. Every misinterpretation and differing view of the Bible arises from a differing view of God. Our attitude towards God, will determine our interpretation and the understanding we have about the scriptures. A true view of God must affect our approach to the Bible. We might be tempted to judge or think of the Bible any way we want but the Bible is not changed by what we wish it is to us, we all must at one point face what the Bible says about us today. We must all approach our Bibles as disciples and not with the mentality of critics or trying to argue and teach the Bible. The

Bible is the written revelation of God. The Bible does not learn from us and will never learn from us but we learn from our Bibles. Many deny this universal truth that the Bible is the written revelation of God. The Bible is God's written testimony or written personal revelation to us. If no man would read it then there was no need for us to have a written record of God's revelation.

The Bible gives guidance in our journey through life to eternity, as well as leads us to a living relationship with the God of the universe. In my early Christian life I have attempted to prove to men or make them believe in God and failed several times. I had not seen from the Bible that Jesus said, "All things have been delivered unto me of my Father: and no one knoweth the Son, save the Father; neither doth any know the Father, save the Son, and he to whomsoever the Son willeth to reveal him." (Mt 11:27) One can never know who Jesus is unless He Himself gives the revelation. The Bible is not an end in itself. Many have attempted to read it and still did not come to know God. "And this is life eternal, that they should know thee the only true God, and him whom thou didst send, even Jesus Christ." (John 17:3)

The Bible is not only a book with words or letters printed on pages of paper. The very nature of the Bible is spiritual. For this reason, everyone who reads this book must approach it spiritually and not carnally. Every man who has approached the Bible from a carnal point of view has been made more carnal than spiritual. If the truth in the Bible will not lead a man to God, it will lead Him further from God. The Bible is a profound book that must be approached carefully and we should not stay on the surface of the Word. Instead, we need to see what is revealed in the depths of the Scriptures. "That which is born of the Spirit is spirit" (John 3:6). "God is Spirit, and those who worship Him must worship in spirit." (John 4:24) We should put John 4:24, 6:63, and 3:6 together: "God is Spirit," "The words

which I have spoken…are spirit," and "That which is born of the Spirit is spirit." The words in the Bible are spirit and life. The life which a man receives at the time of regeneration is spirit, and it takes a man with a spirit to read the words of spirit. Only then will the Bible shine within him, and only then will it become useful to him. No matter how clever and well educated a man is, as long as he is not regenerated, this book is a mystery to him.

The Bible is not understood by talent, research, or intelligence. Since God's word is spirit, only a man with a regenerated spirit can understand it. The root, the very nature, of the Bible is spiritual. If a man does not have a regenerated spirit, he cannot understand this book; it will be a closed book to him. This is why many people do not understand their Bibles. They approach the Bible carnally. I used to be like that before I got saved. To me the Bible was a confusing book and it seemed too voluminous. In the eyes of an unsaved man, no man can finish reading the Bible.

I once said to a group of unbelievers who wanted to quarrel regarding to some Biblical truths, "How much of the Bible do you know? Have you ever finished reading the whole Bible?" Some replied that they had never finished reading it and one of them trying to score some points said, "It is impossible to finish reading the whole Bible!" He showed a sign of satisfaction with the answer he gave thinking that he had put me in a corner. I was holding a small RSV Bible with less than 300 printed pages and proved to them how simple it is to go through the whole Bible within a year by reading at least a page every day and I declared that I read the Bible daily and had been a Christian for more than six years. On the basis of reading the Bible I argued that they were not qualified to argue anything from the Bible which they did not know. This is one of the unbelievers' follies. They think they know the Bible that they have never read and if they did they read it with an unregenerated spirit.

“But the natural man does not receive the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness to him; nor can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned.” (1 Cor 2:14) The natural man has no ability within himself to receive the things of God from the Bible because he is not compatible. I sometimes look with mercy on some foolish unbelievers who claim that they worship God to cover up and deceive a Christian who is trying to show them the way. Deep in their souls they know that they are not born again, but they dismiss the truth for a lie out of pride. Many unbelievers assume they know the Bible better than Christians. How can they know what they don’t read? If they read it, they will soon discover that the Bible itself says that they cannot accept its truths because it is spiritual.

“Have you not read…How do you read…?”

Jesus would always say to people, “Have you not read…? Or “How do you read…?” Reading the Bible is important but how we read is even more important as it affects the value of our effort. “If anyone resolves to do His will, he will know concerning the teaching, whether it is of God or whether I speak from Myself.” (John 7:17) If a man resolves to do God’s will, he will know. In other words, obedience is the one condition for knowing. A resolution to do God’s will is a condition for knowing God’s teaching. If a man has no intention to do God’s will, yet wants to know God’s teaching, he is asking for the impossible. In order to know God’s teaching, a man must first resolve to do His will. This resolution relates to one’s attitude. God wants us to be obedient first in our attitude. If a man is obedient to God in his attitude, God’s teaching will be clear to him. We should not ask what the Bible teaches. Instead, we should ask if we are willing to obey His word. Whether or not the Bible will be open to us depends on our attitude towards God. We are responsible for our attitude, while God is responsible for His teaching. If our attitude is right, God will reveal Himself to us and open our eyes immediately.

When people read the Bible in a wrong way they cannot see the relationship between the Old Testament and the New Testament. Many people who doubt the Bible always want to argue by accusing the Bible of controversy and contradiction. Most people who misjudge the Bible have never read the whole book with the right attitude. Unbelievers want to find out about God through analysis, synthesis, science and reasoning. Job said, “Can you find out the depths of God?” (Job 11:7). No one can find out God by research. God cannot be put into a test tube for an experiment. There is only one way to find God in the Bible and it is by the regenerated spirit. Those who touch God with this spirit will know Him right away. There is no other way except this way. To see the Bible as one unified story about Jesus requires us to view some aspects of the Old Testament in places not as a literal account, but as a foreshadowing, of the events of the New Testament. Some events of the Old Testament must be seen as part of the story, a pre-figuration, of the events of Christ's life. Christ is the main theme of the Bible. We must come into the reality of the person of Christ. It may take years for some people to come to this realization. I hope my readers will see this early.

Some people hate Church, they hate preachers and hate the Bible. “How then shall they call on him in whom they have not believed? and how shall they believe in him whom they have not heard? and how shall they hear without a preacher?” (Rom 10:14) God has provided the way of salvation through the preaching of Christ. Those who hate the channels that God has chosen might miss God. “So belief cometh of hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ.” (Rom 10:17) Unless people realize these things they may not be profited by their Bible readings. The ultimate goal is for us to have faith by hearing the Word of Christ. It is not only the Bible that we need to read but the Person of Christ that we need. If a preacher brings us into this reality then he has been sent by God. Early apostles did not have a complete Bible like we do now, but they brought people into the reality of Christ through their preaching.

When a person receives the Lord Jesus Christ as his Savior, he, with the Lord, also receives a desire to know more about his salvation and the one who saved him (John 15:26). This desire causes the new believer, possibly for the very first time in his life, to open the Holy Bible in a serious attempt to learn what God has to say.

Once in the Scriptures the believer soon realizes that the Bible speaks of much more than just personal salvation and Christ dying on the cross; it speaks of God's whole program for His entire creation from eternity to eternity. It reveals what God wants man to know about God Himself, His creation, and His purpose with His creation. Unless the believer understands this and divides the Bible accordingly (2 Tim. 2:15), he may become overwhelmed by its vast scope and perplexed by its differences. All the Bible's major differences can be reconciled with some study (sometimes very little), but if the believer neglects to study and sort these differences out, he will cheat himself out of understanding not only God's plan and purpose for man in general, but also for himself in particular.

If a person reads the Bible very much he is soon confronted with various laws, judgments, ordinances, commandments, doctrines, kingdoms, covenants, testaments, dispensations, gospels, priesthoods, feasts, tribes, churches, etc., and begins to see some of the Bible's complexity. He is further introduced to events known as the Exodus, Israel's Captivity, Daniel's Seventieth Week, the Rapture, the Judgment Seat of Christ, the Tribulation, the Millennium, the White Throne Judgment, the New Heaven and New Earth, etc., that add even more to its broad variety of topics. Once a reader gets to this point questions usually arise: Where do all these subjects belong? Do they all apply to everyone in every age? Does every precept mentioned in the Bible apply doctrinally to a Christian? "All Scripture is inspired by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for

correction, for training in righteousness; that the man of God may be adequate, equipped for every good work," (2 Tim. 3:16-17)

Paul told his student Timothy to do his best to present himself to God as one approved, "a workman who does not need to be ashamed and who correctly handles the word of truth." (2 Timothy 2:15) What Paul was telling Timothy was to be a student of God's Word who understands how to use it. HOW TO USE IT is the key. The Bible has divisions and the "workman" must "study" to "rightly" divide them. When a believer obeys God's word and with study finds these divisions and applies the truths found in them to their proper place, much of the Bible's complexity disappears and many of its alleged contradictions vanish. Furthermore, many of the different manners, methods, and doctrines in the Bible which often trouble people are reconciled, and the believer begins to see the "big picture" of what God is doing. ALL SCRIPTURE is God-breathed! ALL SCRIPTURE is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness. Because of the wonderful truth of the Grace Gospel, we understand that ALL SCRIPTURE is FOR us but NOT ALL SCRIPTURE is TO us. Paul's letters are written specifically to Gentiles and Jews today. It is very important to understand the purpose of both the New Testament and the Old Testament.

The Bible has been divided into many divisions but there are two main divisions which every believer needs to understand. Most people do not understand what they read. God is a God of Covenants and He always act by His Covenant. The word “Testament” means testimony, Covenant, agreement or arrangement. [Middle English, a will, from Latin testāmentum, from testārī, to make a will, from testis, witness- Something that serves as tangible proof or evidence or a written document providing for the disposition of a person's property after death; a will.] We will use these definitions for the purpose of our study.

The Unfolding of thy Word

“The opening of thy words giveth light; It giveth understanding unto the simple.” (Psalm119:130, KJV)

“Now an angel of the Lord spoke to Philip, saying, "Get up and go toward the south on the road which goes down from Jerusalem to Gaza." This is desolate. And arising, he went; and behold, a man of Ethiopia, a eunuch, a court official of Candace the queen of the Ethiopians, who was over all her treasury, and had come to Jerusalem worshipping, and he was returning. And sitting upon his chariot, he was reading the Prophet Isaiah. Then the Spirit said to Philip, "Go near, and join yourself to this chariot." And Phillip, running up to it, heard him reading the prophet Isaiah, and said, "Indeed, do you know what you are reading?" And he said, "How can I, if not someone guides me?" And he urged Philip to come up and sit with him. Now the portion of the Scripture which he was reading was this: "He was led as a sheep to the slaughter; and as a lamb before its shearer is silent, thus He opened not His mouth. In His humiliation His justice was taken away, and who will recount His generation? For His life is taken away from the earth." So the eunuch answered Philip and said, "I ask you, of whom does the prophet say this; about himself, or about some other person?" And Philip, opening his mouth, and beginning from this Scripture, preached the good news about Jesus to him.” (Acts 8:26-35)

“And he said unto them, These are the words which I spake unto you, while I was yet with you, that all things must be fulfilled, which were written in the law of Moses, and in the prophets, and in the psalms, concerning me. Then opened he their understanding, that they might understand the scriptures, And said unto them, Thus it is written, and thus it behoved Christ to suffer, and to rise from the dead the third day: And that

repentance and remission of sins should be preached in his name among all nations, beginning at Jerusalem." (Lk 24:44-47)

Sometimes people open their Bibles but they still read a closed book. They still need someone to guide them so that they can understand. Some need another book written by another man to guide them. The Eunuch did not know who the prophet was talking about. Philip, opening his mouth, and beginning from this Scripture, preached the good news about Jesus to him. One can read about Christ in the Old Testament and still not see Christ. Jesus had to explain to some people what they failed to see when they read the Scriptures, "And beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself." (Lk 24:27) This scripture combined with many other verses that we will look at in detail as we progress with this study point out that the Bible contains one central message and that is "Jesus and Him crucified". Moses and all the prophets speak about Christ.

People had scriptures, read scriptures and heard scriptures but they did not see how the scriptures where presently being fulfilled in Christ. Jesus had to say, "How then shall the Scriptures be fulfilled, that in this way it is necessary [for it] to happen?" (Mt 26:54) "But all this has happened so that the Scriptures of the prophets shall be fulfilled." (Mt 26:56) We still have this same problem today, that when people read their Bibles they fail to see scripture being fulfilled and how scripture applies to their lives. Jesus said to his opponents, "You search the Scriptures, because you think you will find eternal life in them. The Scriptures tell about me, but you refuse to come to me for eternal life…Don't think that I will be the one to accuse you to the Father. You have put your hope in Moses, yet he is the very one who will accuse you. Moses wrote about me, and if you had believed Moses, you would have believed me. But if you don't believe what Moses wrote, how can you believe what I say?" (John 5:39-47)

When we go to the Lord to read His word, our mind must be open to Him. Our opinions, feelings, heart, and everything we are must be open to Him as well. In other words, we cannot be subjective. We must realize the importance of this matter. If a man is not dealt with in this matter, he cannot read the Bible well. We must be willing and ready to believe what God says to us through His word. We should never read our own thoughts into the Bible.

Sometimes when we read the Bible we fail to see what the Bible is saying until certain events and experiences take place. “At that time Peter and the other disciple did not know that the Scriptures said Jesus would rise to life.” (John 20:9) Most of the times when we read the Bible we are like Peter who could not see one of the basic truths from the Old Testament concerning the death, burial and resurrection of the Christ, even though he had received the revelation that Jesus was indeed the Christ. At first when we go through the Bible we may not realize a lot of things but as we continue to study the Bible, God reveals more and more things, that is why Christians must read their Bibles daily.

“At first, Jesus' disciples did not understand. But after he had been given his glory, they remembered all this. Everything had happened exactly as the Scriptures said it would.” (John 12:16) Only a careful person who studies the Bible taking note of what he is studying will see certain things from scriptures which appear to be hidden. Our ability to remember and retain information is very crucial when we study our Bibles. To reconcile the New Testament and the Old Testament requires us to remember a lot of things. This is hard work. Paul said to Timothy, “Be diligent to show yourself approved unto God, a worker unashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.” (2Tim 2:15) The Holy Spirit will remind us all things that God reveals to us in the Bible but we must do the best we can to study the Bible. (John 14:26).

As I continue to read my Bible, I have continued to discover Christ in both testaments in places I had never seen him before. I was thrilled to discover that when Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness he was prophesying about the death of the Messiah. “And just as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, even so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that everyone who believes in Him should not perish but have eternal life. For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.” (John 3:14-16)

Moses wrote about Christ in many ways but the Jews, the Sadducees and the Pharisees and other people failed to see these things while Christ was in his flesh on earth including his twelve disciples who later discovered and finally understood the truth after Christ was raised from the dead. John the Baptist says it another way in John 1:29 when he sees Jesus, "Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world." When Moses wrote about the Passover Lamb and feast, he was indeed writing about Christ. The whole sacrificial system of the Old Testament was considered by New Testament writers to be typical of the perfect and final sacrifice of Christ. God's people today do not offer animal sacrifices for sins, but people before Christ's death were required to do so.

Jesus is the Central message of the Bible

The first prophecy in the Bible is Genesis 3:15. After the fall of man, after the serpent had deceived man, God promised that the seed of the woman would crush the head of the serpent. This promise concerning the seed of the woman was the first prophecy in the Bible of the coming of the Messiah. This prophecy is fulfilled in Matthew 1:22 and 23. In Galatians 4:4 Paul says that Christ was born under the law and was also born of a

woman. Therefore, Christ came not only to fulfill the law, but also to fulfill the promise that the seed of the woman would crush the head of the serpent.

In Isaiah 7:14 there is another prophecy concerning Christ: “Behold, a virgin shall conceive, and bear a son.” According to Matthew 1:23, the name of this Son was called Emmanuel, which means “God with us.” Therefore, the fulfillment of this promise brought God into man. Matthew 1:22 and 23 indicate this: “Now all this took place that what was spoken by the Lord through the prophet might be fulfilled, saying, Behold, the virgin shall be with child and shall bring forth a Son, and they shall call His name Emmanuel, which being interpreted is, God with us.” This Son brought forth of a virgin is the seed of the woman prophesied in Genesis 3:15. Therefore, the birth of Christ was a great fulfillment of prophecies in the Old Testament.

The central theme of the Bible is Christ. This is an undeniable truth. If a man should forget anything else in this book, I will rest satisfied if he should remember that the major focus of the whole Bible is Christ. The New Testament shows us the reality of Christ and the Old Testament reveals to us the shadow of Christ. We are not them that pursue after shadows but those who pursue after reality. I once had of a man who chased after his own shadow to death thinking that someone was following him wherever he went. The man dived over a cliff thinking that he had finally caught the culprit and fell to his death tragically. Such is the demise of many people as they pursue after God, they dive into shadows and leave out the reality. Christ is the reality of the whole Bible.

Luke 24:25-27 and 44-46 also indicate that the New Testament is the fulfillment of the Old Testament. Verses 25 through 27 say, “He said to

them, O foolish and slow of heart to believe in all that the prophets have spoken! Was it not necessary for the Christ to suffer these things and to enter into His glory? And beginning from Moses and from all the prophets, He interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning Himself." As verse 44 indicates, the Scriptures included the Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms. Luke 24:44-46 go on to say, "He said to them, These are My words which I spoke to you while I was yet with you, that all the things must be fulfilled which have been written in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and Psalms concerning Me. Then He opened their mind to understand the Scriptures; and He said to them, Thus it is written, that the Christ should suffer and rise up from the dead on the third day."

The Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms are the three sections of the entire Old Testament, that is, "all the Scriptures" (v. 27). The Savior's word here unveils that the entire Old Testament is a revelation of Him and that He is its center and content. The fact that the Lord opened the mind of His disciples to understand the Scriptures indicates that to understand the Scriptures requires our mind to be opened by the Lord's Spirit through His enlightening (Eph. 1:18). This means that we can read the Bible with a closed mind. Unless our minds are opened to understand the Scriptures, we are not prepared to study the Bible. Studying the Bible takes more than just reading. We are not supposed to browse through our Bibles like many people do, but we are to STUDY and rightly or correctly divide the Word of truth.

Romans 1:2 speaks of the gospel of God which "He promised before through His prophets in the holy Scriptures." This gospel, which concerns His Son, Jesus Christ our Lord (Rom. 1:3), was promised by God through the prophets in the Scriptures. This indicates that the gospel of God was not an accident but was planned and prepared by God. Before the foundation of the world, God planned to have this gospel. Therefore,

numerous times in the Holy Scriptures, from Genesis through Malachi, God spoke and promised through the prophets regarding the gospel of God. Hence, Romans 1:2 is a further demonstration of the fact that the New Testament is the fulfillment of the Old Testament. Micah 5:2 says, "But thou, Bethlehem Ephratah, though thou be little among the thousands of Judah, yet out of thee shall he come forth unto me that is to be ruler in Israel; whose goings forth have been from of old, from everlasting." This prophecy is fulfilled in Matthew 2:4-6 and Luke 2:4-7. Yes, here we have an instance of the fulfillment of the Old Testament in the New Testament.

However, we need to go on to see something deeper concerning the New Testament as the fulfillment of the Old Testament. Christ is the fulfillment of all that God desired to do with mankind. "For in him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily." (Clo 2:9) "For of him, and through him, and to him, are all things: to whom be glory for ever. Amen" (Rom 11:36) In Christ is the fulfillment of God's will in its totality. God has spoken to us in Christ. "God, who at sundry times and in divers manners spake in time past unto the fathers by the prophets, Hath in these last days spoken unto us by his Son, whom he hath appointed heir of all things, by whom also he made the worlds; ho being the brightness of his glory, and the express image of his person, and upholding all things by the word of his power, when he had by himself purged our sins, sat down on the right hand of the Majesty on high." (Heb 1:1-3)

If we have a deeper understanding of the fulfillment of the Old Testament in the New Testament, we shall see that Christ came not only to fulfill the prophecies but also to fulfill God's eternal dispensation, which is God's dispensing of Himself into His chosen people for the producing of the church. God's dispensing of Himself into His chosen people was promised, prophesied, typified, and shadowed in the Old Testament, and it was fulfilled by Christ's coming in the New Testament. Therefore, Christ came

not merely to fulfill the prophecies concerning His birth, death, and resurrection; He came, in particular, to fulfill the promises, prophecies, types, and shadows concerning God's dispensing of Himself into His chosen people for the producing of the church (Jews and Gentiles or Israel and the nations). Jesus also taught his disciples, "You need to know that I have other sheep in addition to those in this pen. I need to gather and bring them, too. They'll also recognize my voice. Then it will be one flock, one Shepherd." (John 10:16) Jesus was referring to Jews and non-Jewish people who believed in him and those who would later believe in him even to the end of the world. One heart, one mind, one flock and one Shepherd, is God's perfect design for Christianity. It means that true saints in the Biblical perspective should have one doctrine, one Jesus Christ, one Father and the same Holy Spirit. Why do we have various kinds of so called "Christian sects"? It is because of lacking the basic understanding of the Old and New arrangements of worshiping God.

This book will help you understand the Bible in a way you had never imagined. It is my heart's cry that if all ministers of God's word understood the Bible in this way, there would have been fewer contradictions and fewer arguments among believers, but unity among believers could have been the distinguishing watermark from other religions. There are no super Christians, no super brothers and sisters and no superior church denominations, nor is there any room for boasting in the flesh but only one body of Christ-the Church; one Jesus Christ and one God to be worshipped and glorified by all people. Many people have deviated from the truth and feed on human praises, boast in their errors, twist the truth to their own destruction because they have never sat down at the feet of Christ in humility and allow him to transform their lives with the truth. The Bible never contradict itself, and neither is it a confusing book but complicated preachers have complicated the message of the Bible to gullible, ignorant and vulnerable people.

Christ is the seed that is sown in the Old Testament and that develops throughout the Scriptures. In Genesis 3:15 God promised fallen mankind that as the seed of woman Christ would come to crush the head of the serpent. The Bible goes on to reveal that this seed is developed into the seed of Abraham, the seed of Isaac, and the seed of Jacob. In the book of Isaiah we see the further development of this seed into the One born of a virgin and called Emmanuel, the mighty God, and even the everlasting Father (Isa. 7:14; 9:6). Eventually, in the New Testament, the seed sown in the Old Testament will produce many grains, and these grains will become a harvest reaped in the book of Revelation. From this we see that the New Testament is the development and reaping of the very Christ sown in the Old Testament, developed throughout the books of the Bible, and reaped as a harvest in the last book of the New Testament. The New Testament is the completion of the divine revelation.

In Colossians 1:25 Paul says, "I became a minister according to the stewardship of God, which was given to me for you, to complete the word of God." The word of God is the divine revelation. This was not completed before the New Testament. In the New Testament the apostles, especially Paul, completed the word of God in the mystery of God, which is Christ, and in the mystery of Christ, which is the church, to give us a full revelation of God's economy. At the time of Paul the word of God included the Old Testament and the word preached by the early apostles. Although the word of God preached by the early disciples grew and multiplied (Acts 12:24), it was not yet completed according to God's economy. For this completion, God's revelation to Paul was needed.

According to the stewardship of God, Paul became a minister of the church to complete the word of God. Paul is part of the message to the Gentiles. Non-Jewish people could have never understood what the gospel is without Paul. To bring the gospel to the Gentiles needed

someone who could have a Jewish and Gentile understanding of the gospel of Christ. Consider what a lack there would be if we did not have the Epistles of Paul. Without them, there would be no completion of the word of God.

Paul received the revelation of Christ as the mystery of God. In Colossians 2:2 he speaks of the "full knowledge of the mystery of God, Christ." In Ephesians 3:4 Paul speaks of the mystery of Christ. The mystery of God in Colossians 2:2 is Christ, whereas the mystery of Christ in Ephesians 3:4 is the church. Paul was also given the revelation concerning the dispensation of God (2 Cor. 13:14; Eph. 3:14-19). Therefore, the completion of the word of God includes the great mystery of Christ and the church (Eph. 5:32), the full revelation concerning Christ, the Head (Col. 1:26-27; 2:19; 3:11), and the full revelation concerning the church, the Body (Eph. 3:3-6). In Colossians 1:26 and 27 Paul speaks of "the mystery which has been hidden from the ages and from the generations, but now has been manifested to His saints; to whom God willed to make known what are the riches of the glory of this mystery among the nations, which is Christ in you, the hope of glory." This mystery is Christ Himself within us as our life today and our glory in the future. At present, this glory is our hope. From these verses we see that the completion of the divine revelation concerns Christ's coming to dispense God into us as a mystery and as a hope of glory.

I urge the believers of today by the mercies of God to be like those of Beroea, who did not take every message from the pulpit to be the final word but searched from the scriptures to see whether Apostle Paul was teaching the truth. The Bible says, "Now these [Jews] were better disposed and more noble than those in Thessalonica, for they were entirely ready and accepted and welcomed the message [concerning the attainment through Christ of eternal salvation in the kingdom of God] with inclination

of mind and eagerness, searching and examining the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so." (Acts 17:11)

If those early believers checked Apostle Paul's messages, how much more do we need to check modern day messages and teachings in our church gatherings to find out if they are Biblical or not? We are not called to be zombies in Christ but to understand the gospel message for the salvation of all mankind. After a lovely message, go and refer to your Bible and ask, "Is it so?" After reading this book I also desire you to ask yourself the same question. I have never seen such a gullible generation that is quick to take in garbage as gospel like the generation of our time. It baffles me to see people jeering and shouting "Amen" to messages preached out of context. Some of those message a sold for a fortune, as high as US $45 on Dvd.

It is so sad that people go to church meetings one Sunday after another to receive doses of lifeless messages. New Covenant Ministration is lacking. Paul said, "We don't have the right to claim that we have done anything on our own. God gives us what it takes to do all that we do. He makes us worthy to be the servants of his new agreement that comes from the Holy Spirit and not from a written Law. After all, the Law brings death, but the Spirit brings life." (2 Cor 3:5-6) Many Christians today live under the law rather than under grace. They try to revive the Old Covenant ministration which fosters death. The New Covenant which produces life is more glorious is neglected. Paul said that we are ministers of the new agreement as opposed to the Old Covenant. Only New Covenant ministration can produces the Body of Christ.

Nowadays we have many sermons and doctrines broadcasted and published unchecked and accepted into the church denominations forming

traditions that end up dominating the worship gatherings and are emphasized more than God's commandments. Jesus rebuked the Pharisees, "And why do you transgress the commandment of God for the sake of your tradition? …So for the sake of your tradition, you have made void the Word of God. You hypocrites! Well did Isaiah prophecy of you, when he said: "This people honours me with their lips, but their heart is far from me; in vain do they worship me, teaching as doctrines the precepts of men." (Mt 15:3,6-9) These people honoured God with dishonor. They used their lips, but their lives testified that God was not real to them. They worshipped in vain. Worship without reality is of no value before God. They had doctrines about God but no reality.

The Bible in the hands of a carnal man can become man's commandments. It was the same Law of Moses that they used until it became man's commandments. Some people have received as much harm from their Bibles as they do from the Devil. In their zeal to worship God they became hypocrites. They taught man's interpretations as if they were God's commandments. Many people quote their pastors more than the Bible. The Pharisees were the standard that people quoted in those days, yet Jesus called them blind guides and leaders of the blind. There is nothing wrong in quoting your pastor, but if your pastor becomes a substitute for the Holy Spirit in your life, know for certain that you are headed for destruction. People are lost, simply because they don't seek for the truth or they are too reluctant to search for the truth.

Some think searching for the truth is for pastors and ministers of the word. They don't feel any obligation to study their Bibles. Some do not feel the need for searching for the truth. Just because you don't feel like searching for the truth does not mean you don't need the truth. If you have not found the truth yet, it means you are lost. When you don't have the truth you are not in a vacuum, it means there is falsehood filling that gap

of knowledge in your life! People were taught man's commands because they did not seek for a relationship with God. The Pharisees had the Law, but no reality of a relationship with God. Those who had the truth could not be deceived, they believed in Christ in a doubting world. They did not only know who Christ was, but they believed Him, they received Him and they surrendered their lives to Him. The Pharisees were analysts, commented on every miracle Jesus did, doubted the reality of His power using the Law as their justification. Their hypocrisy casted a shadow upon them and they could not see Christ the light shining in the dark. Instead of seeing the glory of God, their shadows of doubt caused by doctrines without reality could not allow them to accept Christ. Overtaken by jealousy and pride and fear of losing their positions in the synagogues they plotted against the Messiah for his death. They kept their synagogue positions and were denied entry into the glorious Church of our Lord Jesus Christ because of error.

Most of the modern so called Christian practices were borrowed from worldly standards and man's ideology yet the Bible is there as our standard. Man's doctrines and opinions are not substitutes for the Spirit of God and His voice in our lives. We need the Lord Jesus more than anything else in this world and the voice of His Holy Spirit to teach us all truth. (Jn14:26, Lk10:39-42) Many are caught up in serving church organizations and ministries rather than having an intimate relationship with the Lord Jesus Himself.

Jesus revealed to me that people can have the wrong teachings as well as false doctrines about Him and lack the genuine experience of Christ. You can have the right doctrine, worship in the right Church but have a wrong experience, or lack the spiritual reality of Christ. The revelation of Christ is about experiencing Christ. It is spiritual reality that issues forth from Christ. One can have an outward revelation, a historical revelation and

understanding of Christ, but lack the present reality of Christ. We need to read our Bibles until we get the mind of God and experience the same Spirit that inspired the writers, only then can the genuine experience of the gospel become real to us. Knowledge and doctrine concerning Christ, must be experienced in reality.

Conclusion

The pages printed in ink of the Bible must link us with the Spirit behind the ink. Many people read their Bibles and fail to believe and obey what they read, because they only see ink and doctrines. Christ is not a doctrine, but He is a Person, a Person to relate with and a Person to be experienced. The Holy Ghost is not a doctrine, but He is our Teacher and the Spirit of Truth and He alone can bring us into the reality of Christ. The gospel is not a story, but a reality, a reality we must all experience. There is so much of the gospel that has been preached and not experienced because many people simply don't believe the gospel. God is not just a set of rules and regulations or do's and don'ts. God is Personal and can be related with. God is not a passive being, or a powerful force, but God is Spirit and those who want to worship Him must worship Him in Spirit and in Reality.